

Nintendo was largely left out of the race. The belated release of the Nintendo 64 to fight Sony's PlayStation didn't help them much. When the console was released in North America, the unit came with just two launch titles. Also, Nintendo used cartridges and not discs for their console – partly to fight piracy but also because of failed disc projects with Phillips and Sony. Also, even though the Nintendo 64 could handle 3D polygons way better than most consoles that came before, their titles lacked the chutzpah of PS discs – the voice overs, the soundtracks, the cut-scenes and more – which made the PlayStation so much more enjoyable.

Microsoft's entry into the game (pun intended), with the Xbox in 2001 became another turning point for the industry, pitting Xbox against PS as the foremost contenders in the gaming arena.

The traditional console's status is still intact but with the emergence of mobile device platforms like Android and iOS, the gaming device arena now has more players. Although, it would be really premature to think that the future of gaming would be limited to the phone platforms. For there just is no comparison between a console designed purely for the pleasure of gaming and a device on which you just happened to be able to play games.

As for consoles themselves, internet distribution is making them even more versatile, enabling players in different locations to play against or with each other and also giving them the option to download and play any game via the internet. In other words, versatility is no more a huge issue when it comes to gaming. The key differentiator might be the amount of control (as well as the ease of control) which each console gives the player.

And that, as history has shown us, is something that competing companies fight with their teeth and nails to bring to you. **d**